Potential energy-displacement graph for a spring

A compressed or extended spring will transfer its stored potential energy into kinetic energy of the mass attached to the spring. The potential energy-displacement graph is shown in Figure 4.11.

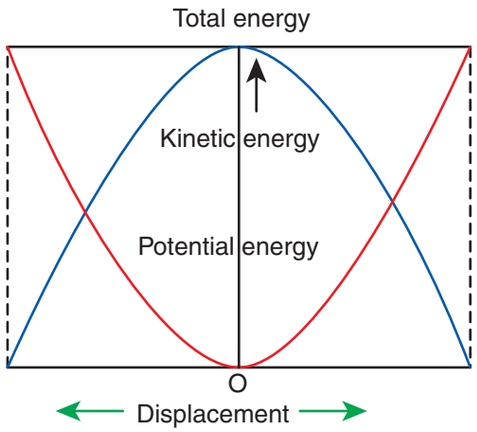


Figure 4.11 Potential energy–displacement graph for a spring-mass system

In a frictionless environment, the energy gets transferred from kinetic to potential and potential to kinetic repeatedly such that the total energy of the system remains constant. At the mean position,

$$\Delta KE = \Delta U \qquad (4.26)$$

EXAMPLE 4.9

Let the two springs A and B be such that $k_A > k_B$. On which spring will more work has to be done if they are stretched by the same force?

Solution

$$F = k_A x_A = k_B x_B$$

$$x_A = \frac{F}{k_A}; \quad x_B = \frac{F}{k_B}$$

The work done on the springs are stored as potential energy in the springs.

$$U_A = \frac{1}{2} k_A x_A^2 \; ; \quad U_B = \frac{1}{2} k_B x_B^2$$

$$\frac{U_A}{U_B} = \frac{k_A x_A^2}{k_B x_B^2} = \frac{k_A \left(\frac{F}{k_A}\right)^2}{k_B \left(\frac{F}{k_B}\right)^2} = \frac{\frac{1}{k_A}}{\frac{1}{k_B}}$$

$$\frac{U_A}{U_B} = \frac{k_B}{k_A}$$

$k_A > k_B$ implies that $U_B > U_A$. Thus, more work is done on B than A.

EXAMPLE 4.10

A body of mass m is attached to the spring which is elongated to 25 cm by an applied force from its equilibrium position.

(a) Calculate the potential energy stored in the spring-mass system?
(b) What is the work done by the spring force in this elongation?
(c) Suppose the spring is compressed to the same 25 cm, calculate the potential energy stored and also the work done by the spring force during compression. (The spring constant, k = 0.1 N m^{-1}).

Solution

The spring constant, k = 0.1 N m^{-1}

The displacement, x = 25 cm = 0.25 m

(a) The potential energy stored in the spring is given by

$$U = \frac{1}{2} k x^2 = \frac{1}{2} \times 0.1 \times (0.25)^2 = 0.0031 \text{J}$$

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